

1955–59

MARCH 3, 1955

In Cambodia, King Norodom Sihanouk abdicates his throne to stand for election as prime minister.

APRIL–MAY 1955

Prime Minister Diem crushes the powerful Binh Xuyen criminal organization in Saigon.

MAY 18, 1955

The movement of about one million refugees—many of them Catholics—from North to South Vietnam is completed.



Refugees during Operation Passage to Freedom, 1954–55

OCTOBER 27, 1955

After defeating Bao Dai in a referendum, Diem proclaims South Vietnam to be the Republic of Vietnam, and names himself as its president.

APRIL 28, 1956

The last French soldier leaves Vietnam.

JULY 1956

The deadline for nationwide elections to reunify Vietnam, one of the terms of the Geneva Accords, passes with no elections held.